

French Defeat at Dien Bien Phu

Committed to a major set-piece battle under unfavorable circumstances, French forces besieged at Dien Bien Phu fought with outstanding courage but could not avoid defeat at the hands of a superior enemy. The Viet Minh triumph ended the colonial era in Indochina.

◀◀ BEFORE

After six years of fighting in the First Indochina War, the French realized that they could not defeat the Viet Minh.

TRUTH DAWNS

By 1953, the French government began to look for an **honorable way of withdrawing from Indochina**. General Henri Navarre, appointed French commander in Indochina in May 1953, had orders to preserve his forces rather than pursue a military victory. The **Viet Minh**, however, launched an invasion of Laos in early 1953, in support of rebels against the French-backed Laotian government. General Navarre felt compelled to respond to the threat.

In the fall of 1953, French General Henri Navarre made the fateful decision to establish a base at remote Dien Bien Phu, inside Viet Minh-controlled territory, near Vietnam's Laotian border. His objective was to disrupt Viet Minh supply lines to their forces in Laos. On November 20, three French parachute battalions dropped into Dien Bien Phu and secured the area after some sharp fighting. Eager to escalate from guerrilla operations to full-scale battle, Viet Minh commander Vo Nguyen Giap ordered substantial infantry forces with artillery to move toward Dien Bien Phu.

Navarre was aware of this Viet Minh response from radio intercepts. Instead of withdrawing, he poured thousands of troops into the Dien Bien Phu base, hoping to inflict a major defeat on the Viet Minh if they chose to attack.

Almost 190 miles (300 km) from their bases at Hanoi, and without usable roads, the French troops depended on supply by air. Navarre assumed the Viet Minh would have their own supply problems, but Giap had a vast army of laborers to move supplies across country.